Target to Double Food Production to 100 Million Tonnes

Food shortage was the biggest worry of Indian leaders after Independence. The country was dependent upon import of food. India imported 2.8 million tonnes of foodgrains in 1948. In the next three years (1949–51), the quantum of food imported ranged between 2 million tonnes and 5 million tonnes. Wheat was the real problem as many of the country's good wheat-producing areas had gone to Pakistan after Partition. Only about 10 million hectares of land was under wheat cultivation in 1950–51, producing just about 6.5 million tonnes of wheat.

Very early, during the First Plan period, India set a target to produce 100 million tonnes of foodgrains by the end of the Third Five-Year Plan (1961–66) to free the country from the scourge of food shortages and the ignominy of importing wheat from the US on terms that were sometimes humiliating.

India's efforts to double foodgrains production in fifteen years did not succeed with production averaging about 81 million tonnes during 1961–62 and 1963–64. In 1964–65, the rainfall was excellent and India achieved its highest foodgrains production of 89 million tonnes. The next two years were drought years. India faced its worst foodgrains crisis from 1965 to 1967. Production collapsed to just 72 million tonnes in 1965–66 and 74 million tonnes in 1966–67.

The situation had become so desperate that Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri actually implored Indians to eat only once a day. About 10 million tonnes of wheat—the largest food transhipment project ever undertaken globally—had to be shipped from the US to India in 1965 to save Indians from starvation.

1947–1964: The Unproductive Years

While the first three Plans (1951–1966) talked a lot about agriculture, land and farmers, industry remained the principal object of attention and